MUGHAL ARMS

Made up of warriors from diverse ethnic backgrounds and fighting traditions, the Mughal army was never remotely homogenous in armour or weaponry. The core of elite heavy cavalry, however, could be expected to wear mail-and-plate armour and carry a round shield of leather or steel. The armour was lighter, cheaper, and, crucially, cooler than its European equivalent. For engaging the enemy at close quarters they typically carried a sword – usually the curved *talwar* – and a percussion weapon such as a mace.

Mail-and-plate coat
The high status Mughal horse-warrior wore a plated cuirass integrated with a coat of mail reaching to his knees. It did not offer the level of protection of all-over plate armour, as missiles and stabbing weapons could potentially penetrate the riveted mail, but it was relatively light and flexible.

Scalloped plates protect skull

Lining made of red silk

Flaps protecting ears and neck

Chainmail protection for face

Securing strap

Plates provide extra protection

Elbow protection

Helmet
Made mainly of mail this Mughal helmet (known as a "top") weighed a very manageable 0.8kg (1.75lb). The two horizontal rings of overlapping plates provided increased protection to the top of the head while the triangular section of mail was worn over the face.

Mace
Simple solid iron maces, like this 16th-century weapon, were widely used by Mughal cavalry and infantry. They could deliver a powerful blow.

Grip

Dastana (arm defence)
A *dastana* is a forearm guard; in European armour it would be called a vambrace. The forearms were obviously a vulnerable area in any close-quarters combat. This example is comprised of two pieces – an outer forearm and hinged inner arm defence – secured with a long pin.

TALWAR

Disc pommel

Indo-Muslim hilt design

SCABBARD

Elaborate gilding

Deeply curved blade typical of the Indian style in the Middle Ages